

» PHOTOLINE MESSI APPRECIATION

1st

2006, The beginning: At 18, Lionel Messi stepped onto the World Cup stage for the first time, coming on against Serbia and Montenegro in Argentina's 6-0 win. There was already something unmistakable about him. The boy from Rosario had arrived on football's biggest stage, beginning a journey that would span six World Cups. GETTYIMAGES

2nd

2008, Olympic gold: Two years later, Messi had his first taste of international gold. At the Beijing Olympics, Argentina beat Nigeria 1-0 in the final to claim the title, with Messi contributing throughout the tournament. It was an early glimpse of the winner he would become, even if the biggest prizes were still waiting in the distance. GETTYIMAGES

